

it also includes Rails (which you'll probably want to check out) and also a number of additional Ruby third-party components. If you just want to dive into Rails, and want a full stack including a web server and database server check out Bitnami's Ruby stack.

A must-have tool if you want to do serious work with Ruby is RVM (Ruby Version Manager). This brilliant package lets you use multiple Ruby versions, and multiple Ruby package versions without getting into a confusing mess. You are likely to find this very useful if you have multiple projects using different versions of the same packages. Installing RVM on Windows is possible, but not directly, it will only work under Cygwin, a Linux compatibility layer for Windows.

Like most programming languages that have been around for a while, Ruby too has a number of alternative implementations. These can be more appropriate than the offi-

cial implementation based on what you need to do with Ruby. JRuby for instance runs on the JVM and gives you access to Java classes. IronRuby runs *on .NET* and lets you use it's features. Rubinius is another alternative implementation of Ruby that uses a JIT compiler for better performance.

If you're looking to develop for iOS and Android, RubyMotion is the implementation to check out, although it is not free like the ones mentioned above. Also unlike the above, it compiles your Ruby code into an app for those platforms — which it would have to for iOS to not run afoul of its rules. If you like Ruby and are looking for a cross-platform way to build a mobile app, it might be worth the money.

One last tool we'd like to mention, is Pry, which is an alternative to the default Ruby shell (irb). The default Ruby shell is — to put it kindly — functional, Pry greatly improves on the default shell, and it is just a single command away (`gem install pry`). 



Bitnami's stack is great if you are getting into Ruby for web development, since it includes web and database servers, and a simple tool to manage them.